

ACT II: THE VOID

CHAPTER 7: THE TRASH COMPACTOR

****LOCATION: THE VOID****

****TIMELINE: NULL****

Side Story D: The Pruned Nobody

****POV: STANLEY (VARIANT 442-B)****

Stanley was not a superhero. He was not a villain. He was a junior accountant from a timeline where humans had evolved to have slightly larger thumbs.

He had been pruned because he filed a tax return 0.004 seconds late, creating a butterfly effect that eventually led to the heat death of his universe.

Now, Stanley lived in a refrigerator.

It was a sturdy refrigerator. A 1950s Smeg. Lead-lined. It was his home, his fortress, and his coffin.

He peeked out through a crack in the door.

The Void stretched out before him. It was a desert of rust and bone. The sky was the color of a bruise that wouldn't heal. And above it all, **It** prowled.

Alioth.

The cloud beast. The smoke monster. The great eraser.

Stanley watched as a new shipment arrived from the sky. A portal opened—a jagged orange tear in the fabric of the grey. Debris rained down. A tank. A billboard for a movie called **Green Lantern 2**. A man in a red suit.

The man hit the sand with a wet **thud**.

"Ouch," the man yelled. He stood up. He brushed dirt off his spandex. "Okay! Who ordered the existential dread with a side of sand?"

Stanley pulled the refrigerator door shut.

Don't engage, he told himself. **New arrivals are loud. Loud things get eaten.**

He huddled in the dark, clutching his most prized possession: a stapler that still had staples in it.

Just survive, Stanley thought. **Just wait for the end.**

Outside, the man in red started singing.

"I'm a Barbie girl! In a Barbie woooooorld!"

Stanley sighed. **He's going to die so fast.**

****POV: WADE WILSON****

The Void didn't just smell like trash. It smelled like **old** trash. It smelled like the back of a Spencer's Gifts that had been set on fire and then urinated on by a kaiju.

I stood up. My back popped. **Crack-crack-pop.**

"Hello?" I called out. "Is this the afterlife? Because if it is, I have some notes on the decor. Very 'Mad Max' meets 'Hoarders'."

No answer. Just the wind, howling through the wreckage of a giant 20th Century Fox logo.

I know that logo, I thought. **I used to work for those guys. Before the merger. Before the Mouse bought the house.**

I looked around.

Sand. Ruins. And... him.

Logan.

He was lying face down in the dirt, a few yards away. He looked like a pile of dirty laundry that someone had thrown out of a moving car.

"Hey!" I jogged over. "Wakey wakey, eggs and bakey! And by bakey, I mean scorching radioactive heat!"

I kicked his boot.

"Get up, peanut. We have a world to save. Or at least, I do. You just have a liver to punish."

Logan groaned. He rolled over.

His face was a mess. Mud caked in his beard. Blood—dark and sticky—matting his hair. He looked at me with eyes that were yellow and bloodshot.

"Where..." he rasped. His voice sounded like gravel in a blender. "Where are we?"

"The Void," I said, sweeping my arm wide. "The end of the line. The cosmic garbage chute. Welcome to the rest of your life. Which, statistically speaking, is probably about fifteen minutes."

Logan sat up. He looked at the sky. He saw Alioth—the purple storm cloud on the horizon.

"What is that?"

"That's the dog," I said. "Don't pet him. He bites. And by bites, I mean he consumes your atomic structure and turns you into purple poop."

Logan stood up. He swayed. He was drunk. Not 'fun party' drunk. 'I want to forget my own name' drunk.

"You shot me," Logan said.

It wasn't a question. It was an accusation. A statement of fact.

"I did," I admitted. "In the head. Point blank. It was very *Of Mice and Men*. 'Tell me about the rabbits, Logan.' *Bang.*"

Logan popped his claws. *SNIKT.*

They came out slow. Reluctant. Even his metal was tired.

"I'm going to kill you," Logan said.

"Get in line," I said. "Take a number. It's a long list. My ex-landlord. My ex-girlfriend's cat. The entire writing staff of *X-Men Origins*."

He lunged.

It was clumsy. I sidestepped. He stumbled past me, slashing the air.

"Woah, easy!" I grabbed his arm. "You're wasted, Wolvie. You're fighting at 10% capacity. You're the Windows Vista of Wolverines."

He shoved me away. "Don't touch me."

He stumbled toward the horizon.

"Where are you going?" I asked.

"Away," he said. "Away from you."

"There is no away!" I shouted. "We're in a void! It's infinite nothingness! That's literally the definition!"

He kept walking.

I watched him go. A lonely, yellow-and-blue figure trudging into the wasteland.

He's broken, the voice in my head whispered. *He's not the Anchor. He's a paperweight.*

But he's all I've got.

"Wait up!" I yelled, running after him. "I know a great bar! It's in the skull of a dead celestial! Happy hour starts at the end of time!"

CHAPTER 8: A MAN-SHAPED SCAR

The bar was real.

Well, "bar" was a generous term. It was a hollowed-out fuselage of a crashed Helicarrier, propped up against the ribs of a giant skeleton. Someone had hung a sign that said "THE LAST CALL" in spray paint.

Inside, it smelled of kerosene and unwashed bodies.

Logan sat at a spool table, staring at a bottle of clear liquid that looked like lighter fluid.

"So," I said, sliding onto a crate opposite him. "Let's talk."

Logan didn't look up. "No."

"Come on. We're partners! We're a buddy cop movie! I'm the loose cannon, you're the grump who's 'too old for this shit'."

"I'm not your partner," Logan growled. "I'm your prisoner."

He took a swig of the lighter fluid. He didn't even wince.

"You're not a prisoner," I said. "You're a volunteer. A conscript. A..."

"I failed," Logan said.

The words were quiet. Heavy. They dropped onto the table like lead weights.

I stopped joking.

"What?"

Logan looked at me. His eyes were wet.

"My world," he said. "The X-Men. The humans. They're dead."

"I know," I said. "I saw the Wikipedia page. 'The Westchester Incident'. Sad stuff."

"You don't know," Logan snapped. "You don't know anything."

He leaned forward. The smell coming off him was intense. Stale beer. Old sweat. And under it all... iron. The smell of old blood that never washed off.

"I wasn't there," Logan whispered. "They called me. Scott. Jean. They called for help. And I was in a bar. I was drunk. I ignored the call."

He tapped the bottle.

"When I got back... it was over. The mansion was burning. The bodies..."

He shuddered. A tremor ran through his adamantium frame.

"I buried them," he said. "All of them. And then I walked away. And I kept walking. And I kept drinking. Until I ended up here."

He looked at me.

"So don't tell me I'm a hero," he spat. "I'm not a hero. I'm the reason they're dead. I'm a man-shaped scar."

I stared at him.

Okay. Heavy. This is... real. This isn't a bit.

What do I do? Make a joke? Deflect?

No. Truth.

"I get it," I said softly.

"You don't—"

"I do," I interrupted. "I really do. I wasn't there for Vanessa. I wasn't there when the bullet hit her. I could have stopped it. I didn't."

I touched my mask.

"We carry it," I said. "The guilt. It's part of the suit. It's the lining."

Logan looked at me. For a second, just a second, the hate in his eyes softened.

Then he blinked. The wall came back up.

"Go to hell," he said.

He stood up.

"I'm leaving."

"Leaving where?" I asked. "To the bathroom? Because it's a bucket in the corner. I checked."

"Anywhere," Logan said. "Anywhere you aren't."

He turned to leave.

"No," I said.

I stood up. I blocked his path.

"Get out of my way, Wade."

"No. I need you. My world needs you. And frankly? You need this. You need redemption."

"I don't want redemption," Logan roared. "I want a drink!"

He shoved me.

I flew back, crashing into the bar. Bottles shattered.

"Okay," I said, picking myself up. "Physical comedy. I can do that."

I drew my katanas.

"If you want to leave," I said, "you have to go through me. And I am very annoying to go through."

Logan popped his claws. *SNIKT.*

"Fine," he said.

CHAPTER 9: THE HOSTAGE DEAL

****POV: WADE****

The fight in the Honda Odyssey (which we found parked outside, don't ask, it's a plot convenience) was cramped.

It's hard to have an epic superhero duel in a minivan. There's no room for choreography. It's just elbows and stabbing.

Beat 1: Mechanics.

Logan lunged from the driver's seat. He drove his claws into my shoulder. ***THUNK.*** The metal slid between my clavicle and my scapula. It felt like being bitten by a steel shark.

I screamed. I jammed my katana handle into his eye socket.

Beat 2: Consequence.

Logan roared. He ripped the claws out—tearing muscle and suit fabric. Blood sprayed the dashboard. It coated the GPS screen, which was currently claiming we were in "Unknown Territory."

I headbutted him. My nose crunched against his forehead.

He bit my ear. Literally bit it off.

Beat 3: Aftertaste.

I tasted copper and earwax. The pain was blinding white hot flashes.

"That's my good ear!" I yelled. "The one I use to listen to Taylor Swift!"

We were tangling in the front seat. The van swerved. We hit a rock.

CRASH.

The van flipped.

The world spun. Dashboard. Roof. Sky. Dashboard. Roof. Sand.

We rolled.

When the world stopped moving, we were upside down.

I was hanging by my seatbelt. Logan was slumped against the roof (which was now the floor).

"Ow," I whispered.

Blood dripped from my nose into my eye.

"Are we there yet?" I asked.

Logan groaned. He popped his neck. ***CRACK.***

"I hate you," he said.

"I know," I said. "It's the sexual tension. It's overwhelming."

I reached for the door handle. It fell off.

"Okay," I said. "New plan. We kick the window out."

We kicked. Together. *Thump. Thump. CRASH.*

Glass shattered. We crawled out into the sand.

We were battered. Bloody. Exhausted.

"Are we done?" I asked, lying on my back, staring at the purple sky.

Logan sat up. He spat out a tooth.

"For now," he said.

"Good," I said. "Because I think we have company."

I pointed.

A group of vehicles was approaching. Mad Max style. Spikes. Skulls. Leather.

"Scavengers," Logan growled.

"Or a fan club," I suggested. "Let's be optimistic."

CHAPTER 10: THE MIND TOUCH

****POV: CASSANDRA NOVA****

Side Story F: The Tasting

Cassandra sat on her throne of bone.

It wasn't a metaphor. It was literally made of the femurs of a Celestial. It was quite comfortable, if you didn't mind the metaphysical hum of dead cosmic energy.

She closed her eyes.

She reached out with her mind.

The Void was loud. So many screaming voices. So much fear. It was a cacophony of terror.

But amidst the noise... a new flavor.

Two new flavors.

One was chaotic. Sour. Like rotting fruit wrapped in candy. A mind that buzzed with static and pop culture references. A mind that knew it was being watched.

Wade Wilson, she tasted. *The clown. The cancer.*

The other flavor...

She inhaled sharply.

It was deep. Earthy. Bitter. Like dark chocolate and old blood. It tasted of regret. It tasted of centuries of pain.

Logan.

She smiled. She licked her lips.

"Bring them to me," she whispered to her lieutenants. Pyro bowed. Sabretooth grinned.

"I want to taste them," she said. "Especially the heavy one. He has so many secrets. So many delicious traumas."

She opened her eyes. They were blue. Pale. Empty.

"It's dinner time," she said.

CHAPTER 11: THE GAUNTLET - PART 1 (THE SETTLEMENT)

****LOCATION: THE SCAVENGER CAMP****

The settlement was built inside the ribcage of a Giant-Man variant.

It was impressive, in a grim way. Huts made of scrap metal and old billboards clung to the massive white bones like barnacles. People—mutants, humans, aliens—moved through the mud, trading scraps of food and water.

"We need supplies," Logan said. He was limping. The crash had done something to his hip that even his healing factor was struggling with.

"We need a new car," I added. "The Odyssey is... well, it's an Odyssey. It's not an Iliad."

We walked into the camp.

Heads turned. Eyes watched us from the shadows. Hungry eyes.

"Keep your head down," Logan muttered.

"Hard to do when you're wearing red spandex," I noted. "I'm basically a walking stop sign."

We found a trader. A Toad variant. He was sitting on a crate, eating a fly.

"We need fuel," Logan said. "And water."

Toad looked us up and down. He licked his lips. His tongue was uncomfortably long.

"What do you have to trade?" Toad asked.

I patted my pockets. "I have a half-eaten chimichanga. A picture of Bea Arthur. And... oh, look! A bullet!"

Toad sneered. "Not enough."

"What do you want?" Logan asked.

Toad pointed.

At the edge of the camp, there was a cage. Inside was a child. A mutant kid. Glowing blue eyes.

"The boss wants the kid," Toad said. "He's an energy source. You bring me the kid, I give you fuel."

I looked at the kid. He looked terrified.

I looked at Logan.

Logan's face was stone.

"No," Logan said.

"Then no fuel," Toad shrugged.

We walked away.

"We take the fuel," Logan whispered.

"Steal it?"

"Take it."

"And the kid?" I asked.

Logan stopped. He looked at the cage. He looked at his hands—hands that had killed thousands.

"We're not heroes, Wade," Logan said. "We're survivors."

"We can be both," I said.

That night, we didn't just take the fuel.

We took the camp apart.

Beat 1: Mechanics.

Logan moved like a shadow. He snapped the neck of the guard by the fuel depot. **CRACK.** Clean. Efficient.

I went for the cage. I sliced the lock. **CLANG.**

The kid looked up. "Are you here to save me?"

"I'm here to make a bad decision," I said. "Come on."

Beat 2: Consequence.

The alarm went off.

Suddenly, the camp was awake. Mutants poured out of the huts. Pyro. Sabretooth. A guy with quills.

We fought back to back.

Logan was a whirlwind. Claws flashing. Blood spraying.

I was... less graceful. I was shooting and quip-ing.

"Sorry! Excuse me! Just passing through! Love what you've done with the place!"

Beat 3: Aftertaste.

We got the fuel. We got the kid to the edge of the camp.

"Run," Logan told the boy.

The boy ran into the dark.

We jumped into a stolen dune buggy. We sped away.

I looked back. The camp was burning.

"We did a good thing," I said.

Logan wiped blood from his claws.

"We made enemies," he said. "That's not the same thing."

CHAPTER 12: THE GAUNTLET - PART 2 (THE RUINS)

LOCATION: THE FOX LOT

We drove for hours.

The landscape changed. The sand gave way to concrete. Broken slabs. Rebar.

We stopped at a ruin.

It was a statue. Or part of one. A giant torch.

"Lady Liberty?" Logan asked.

"Planet of the Apes," I corrected. "Or... wait."

I wiped the dust off a plaque.

20th CENTURY FOX.

It was the logo. The monolith. The fanfare structure.

I sat down on the letter 'X'.

"This is it," I said. "This is where I came from."

Logan looked at the ruins. "It's just rocks."

"It's not just rocks!" I shouted. "It's history! It's *X-Men*. It's *Daredevil*. It's *Elektra*! Okay, maybe not *Elektra*. But it's my home!"

I felt a lump in my throat.

It's gone. All of it. The studio. The universe. The stories.

"Everything ends," Logan said. He sat down next to me. He didn't look at me. He looked at the horizon.

"Does it have to?" I asked. "Why does it have to end? Why can't we just... keep going?"

"Because nothing lasts," Logan said. "Not even us."

He pulled out a cigar. He lit it. The smoke smelled of comfort.

"I miss them," I whispered. "Vanessa. Blind Al. Even Weasel. I miss my world."

"Then fight for it," Logan said.

"I am," I said. "But I'm tired, Wolvie. I'm so tired."

He looked at me. He put a hand on my shoulder. It was heavy. Warm.

"Me too, kid," he said. "Me too."

We sat there for a long time, watching the sun set over the ruins of a dead studio. Two relics of a bygone era, smoking in the dark.

CHAPTER 13: THE GAUNTLET - PART 3 (THE AMBUSH)

****LOCATION: THE CANYON****

We were ambushed in the canyon.

It was a good spot for an ambush. High walls. Narrow path. Classic.

BOOM.

An explosion rocked the buggy. We flipped.

I crawled out of the wreckage. My leg was backwards. I snapped it back into place. ***CRUNCH.***

"Motherfluffer!"

"Wade!" Logan yelled.

He was pinned. A piece of the chassis was on his chest.

And standing over him was Sabretooth.

Not the Liev Schreiber one. The Tyler Mane one. The big one. The one who looked like a lion that did steroids.

"Well, well," Sabretooth growled. "The runt."

"Victor," Logan wheezed.

"I've been waiting for this," Sabretooth said. He extended his claws. They were long. Dirty.

I tried to run. I tried to help.

But Pyro was there. He blasted me with fire.

"Hot! Hot! Hot!" I rolled. I burned. My skin bubbled.

I watched, helpless, as Sabretooth raised his hand.

"Time to die, Jimmy," Sabretooth grinned.

Beat 1: Mechanics.

Logan roared. He didn't try to lift the car. He popped his claws **through** the car door, stabbing Sabretooth in the foot.

Sabretooth howled. He stepped back.

Logan shoved the car off. It took every ounce of strength. Muscles tore. Veins popped.

He stood up.

Beat 2: Consequence.

They collided. It was primal. No technique. Just weight and hate.

Claws met claws. Sparks showered them.

Sabretooth bit Logan's shoulder. Logan stabbed Sabretooth's gut.

They were a ball of fur and rage.

Beat 3: Aftertaste.

Logan won.

He took Sabretooth's head off. **SNICK-SLICE.**

The head rolled to my feet.

Logan stood there, panting, bleeding from a dozen wounds.

He looked wild. He looked like an animal.

He looked at me. His eyes were blank.

"Logan?" I whispered.

He blinked. The man came back.

He fell to his knees.

CHAPTER 14: THE AFTERMATH

We camped in the canyon.

We didn't talk. We just sat by the fire, healing.

The smell of burning mutant flesh (Sabretooth's corpse) hung in the air.

I looked at Logan. He was staring at the fire. He looked older. Smaller.

"You saved me," I said.

"I saved myself," he grunted.

"No," I said. "You could have run. You stayed."

He didn't answer.

I realized something then.

He wasn't the Worst Wolverine because he was weak. He was the Worst Wolverine because he cared too much. And it broke him.

"Thank you," I said.

He grunted. "Shut up."

"Okay," I said. "But for the record? That decapitation was top tier. Solid 9 out of 10. You lost a point for the landing."

He smirked. Just a little.

It was the first time I'd seen him smile.

It looked like hope.

CHAPTER 15: THE SILENCE

We drove for another day. The canyon opened up into a flat, grey plain.

The silence between us had changed. It wasn't the hostile silence of the bar. It wasn't the awkward silence of the Honda Odyssey. It was a companionable silence. The silence of two guys who had seen some shit and killed a giant cat-man.

"You know," I said, breaking the quiet because I am allergic to it. "We make a good team. Red and Yellow. Ketchup and Mustard."

Logan didn't snarl. He just adjusted his grip on the wheel. "Don't push it."

"I'm just saying. We could franchise this. *Deadpool & Wolverine: The Road Trip*. *Deadpool & Wolverine: Miami Nights*."

"Stop," Logan said.

"Okay. Stopping."

I looked out the window. The Void was endless. Just ruins and dust.

We're never getting out of here, the voice whispered. *This is it. Purgatory.*

But I looked at Logan. He was solid. He was real. And for the first time in a long time, I didn't feel alone.

CHAPTER 16: THE CAMPFIRE (SETUP)

We stopped for the night near a cluster of rocks that offered some shelter from the wind.

We built a fire out of driftwood and pieces of a shattered "Stark Industries" sign.

The fire crackled. It was the only light in the universe.

I sat on a rock, sharpening my katanas. *Shhhk. Shhhk.* The sound was rhythmic. Meditative.

Logan was sitting opposite me, cleaning his claws. He used a rag he'd found in the buggy. He wiped the blood away with a tenderness that was surprising.

"Why do you wear the suit?" Logan asked.

I stopped sharpening. "What?"

"The suit," he said. "The yellow one. Why do you wear it? You didn't wear it in your timeline. You wore black leather. Like a biker."

Logan stopped cleaning. He stared at the fire.

"Scott," he said. "Scott wanted me to wear it."

"Cyclops?"

"Yeah. He said... he said the X-Men needed to be symbols. Bright. Hopeful. He said people needed to see us coming."

He laughed. A bitter sound.

"I told him he was an idiot. I told him I wasn't a billboard. I told him I wasn't a hero."

He looked at his claws.

"I never wore it. Not once. Until..."

He trailed off.

"Until the funeral?" I asked softly.

He nodded.

"I put it on," he whispered. "After they died. I put it on to bury them. Because... because I wanted them to know I was one of them. Finally."

He looked at me. The firelight danced in his eyes.

"But it was too late. They were dead. And I was just a clown in a yellow suit."

CHAPTER 17: THE CONFESSION

The Bestseller Moment

The fire popped. A spark flew up into the dark.

I looked at him. The Wolverine. The legend.

He looked small. He looked broken.

He bleeds like it matters. I bleed like a punchline.

"I didn't just ignore the call," Logan said. His voice was barely a whisper. "I was... I was afraid."

I froze.

"Afraid?"

"I was afraid that if I went... I'd kill them."

He looked at his hands.

"I lose control, Wade. You know that. The Berserker Rage. It's not a superpower. It's a disease. I was afraid I'd hurt Jeannie. Or the kids."

Tears leaked out of his eyes. He didn't wipe them away.

"So I stayed away. I drank. I told myself I was protecting them by not being there."

He sobbed. A racking, ugly sound.

"But they needed me. The humans... they came with Sentinels. They slaughtered them. And I was safe in a bar, staring at a bottle."

He looked at me. His face was a mask of agony.

"I didn't kill them, Wade. But I let them die. Is there a difference?"

I stared at him.

I wanted to make a joke. I wanted to say something about how that's a classic trope. I wanted to diffuse the tension because the tension was crushing me.

But I couldn't.

Because he was right.

And because I knew exactly how he felt.

I stood up. I walked around the fire.

I sat down next to him.

I didn't hug him. He would have stabbed me.

I just sat there. Shoulder to shoulder.

"No," I said. "There isn't a difference. But you're here now."

"Does it matter?" he asked.

"It matters to me," I said. "And it matters to the kid we saved. And it matters to the universe we're going to save."

I pulled out the picture of Vanessa.

"We messed up, Logan. We both did. We failed the people we loved."

I put the picture in the fire.

It curled. It blackened. It turned to ash.

"So let's not fail the next ones," I said.

Logan watched the picture burn.

He took a deep breath. He wiped his face.

"Okay," he said.

"Okay?"

"Okay. Let's save your damn world."

He stood up. He offered me a hand.

I took it.

His grip was strong. Anchor strong.

"Maximum Effort?" he asked.

I smiled beneath my mask.

"Maximum Effort."